

ShakeStation Vending

One smart blender in a busy gym, \$12k a month, no staff, no storefront.

What It Is

An automated protein-shake vending business. You place self-serve smart blender machines in high-traffic gyms, universities, and sports centers. Customers pick a flavor on the touchscreen, pay by card or cash, and get a fresh, blended, ready-to-drink shake in under a minute. The machine tracks every sale and reports live data to your phone, and some models self-clean and self-refill.

How It Makes Money

You earn the margin on every shake sold 24/7 with no employees. Revenue scales by placing more machines once one location proves profitable. Add-ons: branded supplement upsells, sponsored flavors from supplement brands, and a small revenue-share or flat rent paid to the gym for the spot.

Startup Costs

- Smart protein-shake vending machine (Alibaba: "automatic protein shake vending machine" / "smart blender vending machine"): \$4,500–\$12,000 per unit
- Shipping + import duty per machine: \$400–\$1,200
- Initial ingredient stock (protein powder, milk/water base, fruit, cups): \$400–\$800 per machine
- Card payment system / telemetry (often built in): \$0–\$300
- LLC, insurance, permits/food handling: \$500–\$1,500
- Gym placement deposit / first month rent or rev-share: \$0–\$500
- Branding/wrap + signage: \$300–\$700
- **Total to launch (first machine): \$6,000–\$15,000**

The Numbers

- Cost per shake (powder + base + fruit + cup): \$1.20–\$2.00
- Sell price: \$6–\$9
- Profit per shake: \$4.50–\$7.00
- A busy gym machine sells 50–90 shakes/day
- 70 shakes/day x \$5.50 profit x 30 days = **~\$11,500/month profit per machine**
- Gym rent/rev-share (\$300–\$600/mo) still leaves \$10,000+ net. Place 3–4 machines = **\$30,000–\$45,000/month.**

How To Start

1. Order one machine from a vetted Alibaba supplier; confirm card payments, remote telemetry, and parts/warranty support.
2. Form an LLC and get a basic food-handling permit for your area.
3. Pitch 1–2 busy gyms a revenue-share or flat monthly rent for floor space (gyms love an amenity they don't staff).
4. Dial in 4–6 popular flavors and source ingredients from a bulk supplement wholesaler.
5. Install, wrap the machine in clean branding, and set pricing on the touchscreen.

6. Monitor sales from your phone, restock 2–3x/week, and track which flavors move.
7. Once one machine clears profit, reinvest into machines 2, 3, and 4 in similar locations.

Where To Get Customers

Foot traffic is the customer — your job is placement: big-box and boutique gyms, CrossFit boxes, university rec centers, sports complexes, MMA/jiu-jitsu academies, and corporate fitness centers. Negotiate placement directly with gym owners and facility managers.

Pro Tips

- Location is everything — one machine in a 2,000-member gym beats five in dead spots, so vet daily foot traffic before signing any placement.
- Keep ingredients fresh and the machine spotless; a single bad or dirty shake at a gym kills word-of-mouth in a tight community.
- Offer the gym a small rev-share instead of begging for free space — owners say yes fast when they get paid, and you still net 90%+.